



CAMBRIDGE
English

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English Qualifications

B2 First **for Schools**

Writing tasks: writing a **review**

Reviews in B2 First (FCE) exam are written for a website, a magazine or a newspaper.

You always have to do two things **describe** and **discuss** something, for example, a **film**, a **book**, a **restaurant**, an experience or whatever the task might require you to talk about. Also, you have to make a **recommendation** at the end of your text.

Unlike an essay a review should be written in an informal or neutral register, this means:

- you **CAN** use phrasal verbs
- you **CAN** use idioms
- you **CAN** use contractions

Title

Use the name of the **film, book** or **restaurant**.

Introduction

Identify what you are reviewing (**actors, director etc.**).
Try to catch the reader's attention (ask a **narrative** question).

1st body paragraph

Describe the book, film, restaurant

2nd body paragraph

Comment on the questions you have been asked

Conclusion

Summarize your review with a recommendation

We will use the example **FCE review topic** below:

You see this announcement in your college English-language magazine.

Book reviews wanted

Have you read a book in which the main character behaved in a surprising way?

Write us a review of the book, explaining what the main character did and why it was surprising. Tell us whether or not you would recommend this book to other people.

The best reviews will be published in the magazine.

Write your **review** (140–190 words)

Step 1: Briefly analyse the given topic...

Paper 2

The first thing you need to do is to underline a **description part** –in other words, just find what needs to be described.

Secondly, find a **discussion part** – in other words, try to find the **specific points** you need to **comment** on in your text.

Finally, find the **target reader** so you know exactly who you are writing for and who is going to read your review.

You see this announcement in your college English-language magazine. (our readers)

Book reviews wanted

Have you read a book in which the main character behaved in a surprising way? (to describe)

Write us a review of the book, explaining what the main character did and why it was surprising. (to comment)

The best reviews will be published in the magazine.

Now we have all **three elements** we need to write a great review:

You need to describe:

Book in which the main character behaved in a surprising way

You need to answer/discuss:

1. What did the main character do?
2. Why it was surprising?

Who is the target reader: *college English-language magazine.*

We know now that the target readers are **students, teachers** and **probably parents** so the writing style should be neutral or informal.

We don't need to be **too formal** because after all some of the readers are **students**, but we also don't want to be **too informal** as some of the readers are teachers and parents.

Now we can start building our structure and writing a review.

Step 2: Title

The review should start with the title, and there are few simple ways to write it:

- imagine you're reviewing a **book** you can write: **[Title] by [Author]**
- if you were reviewing a **restaurant** you could write: **[name of the restaurant] – a review**

***Title (book):** Dark Souls by Stephen King (by)*

***Title (restaurant):** Taco Bell in London – a review (a review)*

We will use **this title** in our **guide**:

Example:

TITLE: Time Machine by Adam Smith

 **Tip:** Nothing prevents you from writing something **more unique** but it has to point to what you are going to review.

Step 3: Introduction

Paper 2

Use the introduction to **identify the thing** you are going to be reviewing and **provide details** like the genre (i.e. a science fiction novel, a horror movie) or location (if it's a restaurant).



INTRODUCTION

The **other function** of your introduction is to **engage the reader**. You can do it by asking **a question**.

Make your introduction at least **2 sentences** long.

Example:

INTRODUCTION: What would you do if you could travel back in time? Most people would probably meet their great-great-grandparents, but Tom Lee, the main character of the novel Time Machine by Adam Smith finds himself in a completely unexpected situation and he has to make a very difficult decision that will change history as we know it.

– question

– details about the book and main character

Step 4: The body paragraphs (main content)

Paper 2

The **body paragraphs** are the main parts of your review so they should be the **longest** and carry **most of the information**. Also, here you **describe the points** you've found in *(Step 1)*

You need to answer/discuss:

1. What did the main character do?
2. Why it was surprising?

You can use **idioms**, and **phrasal verbs** – neutral/informal language is appropriate for your target reader – **students and teachers**.

TIP: What if you don't read books?

Don't waste your time looking for a **real book** to match your review.

Invent one, it doesn't have to be real!

And yes that may sound difficult: you have to invent a book and then write a review about your invented book!

So instead take a **tv series** you like, take a **film** you like and transform them into books. That's simple!



Example:

[Who is the main character and what did he do? – describe]

Tom, a teacher in a little town in Rotherham, finds a mysterious time portal in the back of a ragged diner which takes him back to the year 1935. Eventually, he makes the unexpected decision to stop Michael James Newton from brutally killing President John F. Kennedy on 22.11.1963.

[Why it was surprising? – comment]

Tom could choose many other and more personal things to do, but he decides to try and change history to a degree that he cannot predict. In my opinion, that came definitely unexpected and if I were in his position I probably wouldn't even consider a task this far-reaching.

– own opinion

– descriptive/interesting vocabulary

– relevant details about the main character and book

Step 5: Conclusion / Recommendations

Finally, we need to make a **recommendation** because after all, that's the **only reason** why anyone would read a review they want to know what the reviewer thinks about the **book, film or restaurant**.

A good final paragraph of a review does exactly **two things**

- it includes a recommendation
- and a final sentence to round off the review

Example:

CONCLUSION: I definitely recommend "Time Machine" to everyone who has already read some of Adam Smith's novels as well as to those who like stories with twists and turns around every corner plus you get some modern history on top of that. For me, it was absolutely worth reading and I'm sure you won't be disappointed.